

Lesson 18

Case Study: Handling Customer Complaints



Warm-Up

- What is the worst customer service experience you have heard of?
- Why do you think customers make complaints?



Role-play

CASE STUDY 1:

Situation: A customer named Maria calls Tech Solutions because her internet connection has been down for several hours.

Maria: Hi, my internet is out, and it's been down for a few hours. I need it for an important meeting.

John (Customer Service Rep): I'm sorry for the inconvenience, Maria. Let me check your account and see what's happening. Could you please provide your account number?

Maria: Sure, it's 12345.

John: Thank you! I see there's an outage in your area. It should be resolved within the next hour.

Maria: Okay, but I really need it for my meeting.

John: I understand. I can escalate this and provide you with a mobile hotspot until the service is restored.

Maria: That would be great! Thank you!

John: You are welcome! I'll send you the details and follow up in about an hour.

Analysis Questions:

1. What steps did the customer service representative take to address Maria's issue?
2. How did John demonstrate empathy towards Maria's situation?
3. What was the solution provided to ensure Maria could continue with her meeting?
4. How did the follow-up offer enhance Maria's experience?

CASE STUDY 2:

Situation: A customer named David calls SmartTech regarding a defective smartphone he purchased.

David: Hi, my smartphone won't turn on. I'd like to return it.

Sam (Customer Service Rep): You need to send it back, but you'll have to pay for shipping.

David: But it's defective. Shouldn't that be covered?

Sam: That's company policy. If you want a refund, you have to pay the shipping.

David: This is frustrating! I just want to return a faulty product.

Sam: Sorry, but there's nothing I can do. If you want help, you can find our return policy on the website.

David: This is unacceptable.

Sam: That's our policy. Sorry.

Analysis Questions:

1. What issues did David face when trying to return his smartphone?
2. How did the customer service representative fail to meet David's needs?
3. What could the company have done to improve this interaction?
4. What policies negatively impacted David's experience?

Discussion

- What are some best practices for effective customer service interactions?
- How important is empathy in customer service, and how can it be demonstrated?
- What strategies can companies implement to prevent negative customer experiences?
- How can feedback from customers be used to improve service quality?
- In what ways can technology enhance or hinder customer service?



Practice

A. Fill-in the Blanks Speaking Activity

Instructions: Complete the sentences with the correct words. Then, practice reading the full sentence aloud with a partner.

apologized	understand	refund	mistake	help	delay
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1. I'm very sorry for the _____ with your order.
2. I completely _____ how frustrating this must be.
3. We can offer you a full _____ or a replacement.
4. Please accept our _____ for the inconvenience.
5. Let me see how I can _____ you today.
6. There was a small _____ with the delivery.

B. Multiple Choice Speaking Activity

Instructions: Choose the best response for each situation. Then, act out a mini-conversation with a partner using your choice.

1. A customer says, “The product I received is damaged”. What should you say first?

- A) It's not our fault.
- B) I'm sorry to hear that. Let me help you.
- C) Can you buy another one?

2. A customer says, “I never received my order.” What should you say?

- A) I don't know what happened.
- B) I will check the delivery status right now.
- C) Maybe you made a mistake.

3. A customer is angry about a late delivery. What is the best action?

- A) Listen carefully and apologize.
- B) Interrupt and explain your side.
- C) Tell the customer to wait longer.

4. A customer says, “I received the wrong item.” What is the best response?

- A) That's not possible.
- B) Could you please send me a photo of the item you received?
- C) Please just return it yourself.

5. A customer is unhappy with the service they received. What should you say?

- A) I'm sorry you feel that way. Let's see how we can fix it.
- B) There's nothing we can do.
- C) It wasn't my fault.



Production

ROLE-PLAY

You will work in pairs to:

1. Choose or create a complaint situation:

- i. Late delivery
- ii. Damaged product
- iii. Wrong order
- iv. Poor customer service
- v. Product not working after purchase

2. Plan a short dialogue (6–8 exchanges between customer and customer service).

3. Use at least 4 key phrases from the lesson:

Useful Phrases:

1. *"Could you please tell me more about the problem?"*
2. *"Thank you for your patience."*
3. *"I'll make sure this doesn't happen again."*
4. *"Is there anything else I can do for you today?"*
5. *"I'm very sorry to hear that."*
6. *"Let me see how I can help you."*
7. *"We can offer you a refund or a replacement."*
8. *"I completely understand."*

Example Conversation

Customer: Hello, I ordered a chair from your website, but it arrived broken.

Customer Service: I'm very sorry to hear that. Let me see how I can help you. Could you please send us a photo of the damage?

Customer: Yes, I can send a picture right now.

Customer Service: Thank you. After we receive it, we can send you a replacement or offer you a full refund.

Customer: I would like a replacement, please.

Customer Service: Of course. We will send it today with express delivery. Thank you for your patience.

Discussion

- What was the most effective way you heard someone handle a complaint during the role-plays? Why was it effective?
- Which polite phrases or strategies do you think are most important when talking to an unhappy customer?



Key Vocabulary

Word/Phrase	Use	Example
We will make sure this doesn't happen again.	To promise action to prevent future problems.	We will make sure this doesn't happen again by improving our packaging process.
Could you please provide more details?	Could you please provide more details?	Could you please provide more details about the problem with the product?
We can offer you a refund or a replacement.	To present solutions to the customer's problem.	We can offer you a refund or send a new item immediately.
Please accept our apologies.	To formally apologize, often for bigger problems.	Please accept our apologies for the delay and inconvenience.
We are looking into this issue.	To tell the customer you are investigating the problem.	We are looking into this issue and will update you shortly.



Wrap-Up

“Customers may forget what you said but they’ll never forget how you made them feel.” — Maya Angelou

What is the most important thing to remember when handling a customer complaint?